🚀 Kernel & QEMU Merge Window Tracker

Visual timeline for merge windows and RHEL deadlines

Merge Window (Open) | Bugfix Only (Closed) | RHEL Deadline

📋 Release Cycle Information

🐧 Kernel Release Cycle (~9-10 weeks total)

- **Merge Window:** 2 weeks (new features accepted)
- **Bugfix Period:** 7-8 weeks (only bugfixes, no new features)
- **Release:** Then cycle repeats
- **Frequency:** ~Every 2-2.5 months

💻 QEMU Release Cycle (~3.5-4 months total)

- **Merge Window:** 2-2.5 months (new features accepted)
- **Bugfix Period:** 5-6 weeks (only bugfixes, no new features)
- **Release:** Then cycle repeats
- **Frequency:** ~Every 4 months

🎯 RHEL 10.3 - Deadline: May 16, 2026

Kernel Timeline

Early Mar Merge	Mar-Apr Bugfix	Mid-Apr Merge ⚠️	Apr-May Bugfix Only

QEMU Timeline

Jan-Mar Bugfix	Mid-Apr → May 16 Merge Window ✅

✅ **Strategy for RHEL 10.3:**

🐧 **Kernel: Must be submitted in next few weeks (before mid-April merge window closes)**
💻 **QEMU: More time available - merge window re-opens mid-April and stays open until deadline**

⚠️ **Critical Window:**

Last kernel merge window (~Mid-April) is the FINAL chance. After that, only bugfixes until May 16!

🎯 RHEL 10.4 - Deadline: October 16, 2026

Kernel Timeline

Mid-Jun Merge	Bugfix	Mid-Aug Merge ✅	Bugfix	Mid-Oct Merge ⚠️		Too Late

QEMU Timeline (Cycle 1)

Mid-Apr → Mid-Jul Merge ✅	Bugfix	Aug Release

QEMU Timeline (Cycle 2)

Aug Release	Late Aug → Oct 16 Merge ✅	Nov Freeze → Dec Release

✅ **Strategy for RHEL 10.4:**

🐧 **Kernel: Target mid-August merge window (safest option). Mid-October is too risky!**
💻 **QEMU: Two good windows available:**

- Mid-April → Mid-July (if ready early, not tied to kernel)
- Late August → October 16 (more runway, aligns with kernel timeline)

⚠️ **Important Notes:**

🐧 Mid-October kernel merge window is probably too late for Oct 16 deadline
💻 QEMU has more flexibility but earlier submission (Mid-July window) is ideal if not tied to kernel code

📌 Quick Reference

Release	Deadline	Kernel Strategy	QEMU Strategy
RHEL 10.3	May 16, 2026	Submit in next few weeks	More time (until May 16)
RHEL 10.4	Oct 16, 2026	Target mid-August window	Mid-July or Late Aug-Oct